

Opening: style and voice

1. The novel opens in present tense with "The Deliverator" — Hiro's name withheld for pages. What does the epic register (elite order, esprit, kamikaze pilot) do when applied to pizza delivery? Where exactly does the irony land: on Hiro, or on the world that makes this the only heroism available?
2. Stephenson's list of what America still does best — music, movies, microcode, high-speed pizza delivery — is formatted as a broken-out list mid-paragraph. Why the typographic interruption? What's the effect of the fourth item?
3. The name "Hiro Protagonist." Y.T. calls it stupid; Hiro says she'll never forget it. Is this a joke at the reader's expense, metafiction, or characterization? Defend one.

World-building through institutions

4. Trace how CosaNostra Pizza University "solved" the late-pizza dispute. What is Stephenson satirizing about corporate rationality — and why does the fix (smart boxes) bypass human nature rather than address it?
5. Burbclaves are "city-states with their own constitution, a border, laws, cops." What's been privatized in this world, and what remains public? Is anything left?
6. The MetaCops read a legal disclaimer while arresting Y.T. ("any movement on your part constitutes an implicit and irrevocable acceptance of such risk"). What is the relationship between law and force here? Compare the two registers: the first MetaCop's legalese vs. the second's "freeze, sucker."
7. Mr. Lee's Greater Hong Kong welcome poster is written in broken English yet the franchise runs the most sophisticated technology we've seen (millimeter-wave radar, the Rat Thing). What's the satirical point of that mismatch?

The Metaverse

8. The Street's dimensions come from a protocol; its physics are negotiable (avatars pass through crowds, Da5id makes physics "cartoonish"). What does it mean that the Metaverse is more law-governed than Reality — where does authority live in each?
9. Hiro is broke in Reality but "a warrior prince" in the Metaverse. Is the Metaverse compensation, escape, or a real domain of achievement? Use the sword-fight with the businessman: does Hiro's victory mean anything?
10. Juanita's insight: the human mind absorbs information "if you put the right face on it" — her faces made The Black Sun succeed. Yet she now refuses the Metaverse because it distorts how people talk. Reconstruct her position. Is it consistent?
11. Brandy and Clint avatars vs. custom avatars vs. black-and-white public-terminal users: how does class reappear inside a world where "your avatar can look any way you want"?

Identity, race, class

12. Hiro's background: Korean mother, Black father, Army-brat childhood where "Military" was the ethnic group. How does the novel connect his "general disorientation" about class to his relationship with Juanita and to his career? Contrast with Da5id, who "has always been certain of everything."
13. The sword-fight begins because the Nipponese businessman implies Hiro can't legitimately own the swords. How does the exchange about the POW camp and Nagasaki reframe who is heir to what? What is Hiro doing with the Aunt Jemima dialect he adopts mid-fight?

14. Y.T. is fifteen, female, and consistently the most competent person on the page. How does she manage other people's perceptions (the manager, the MetaCops, Studley)? What does the dentata suggest about the world she operates in?

The virus thread + synthesis

15. Assemble the Snow Crash clues so far: a "drug" offered in the Metaverse, a bitmap of static, the Brandy's whispered "babble," Da5id's crash, Juanita's warnings, the Librarian on Babel. What hypothesis do these chapters want you to form? What would it mean for information to work like a virus — on a computer, on a brain?
16. The Librarian corrects the Babel story: God didn't destroy the tower; he caused "an informational disaster." Why does Stephenson want the catastrophe to be linguistic rather than architectural? Connect to Taxilinga, the MetaCops' translator, and the Abkhazian manager's English.
17. The Rat Thing chapter shifts into the dog's POV ("porterhouse steaks grow on trees"). Why grant interiority to the cyborg and withhold it from, say, the jeeks? What is the chapter arguing about where personhood lives in this world?
18. Closing evaluation: Snow Crash is 1992's guess at the internet's future. Where has it proven predictive (VR, avatars, gig work, privatization) and where does its satire miss? Is the book celebrating or condemning the world it invents — can you tell?